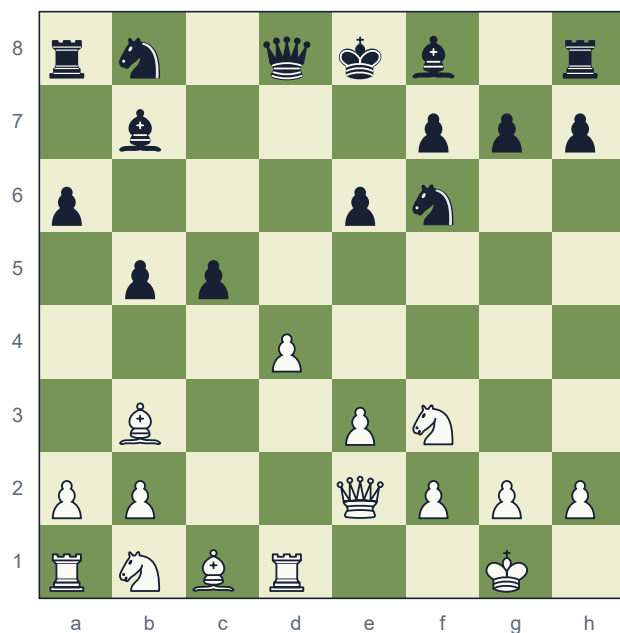


Queen's Gambit Accepted

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Recover c4 with a developing bishop move when possible. Use Nf3 to restrain ...e5, then e3 and Bxc4. You do not need to win the pawn back immediately.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

After ...c5 and exchanges on d4, White may have an isolated d-pawn. Before that, the open center and quick development are the important features.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black returns the pawn to develop freely, or tries ...b5 to hold it. The latter often gives you targets for a4 and undermining moves.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The Queen's Gambit is not an instruction to sacrifice c4 forever.
2. Against ...b5, attack the supporting pawn chain instead of bringing the queen out repeatedly.
3. An isolated d-pawn is playable with active pieces; avoid drifting into a passive blockade.

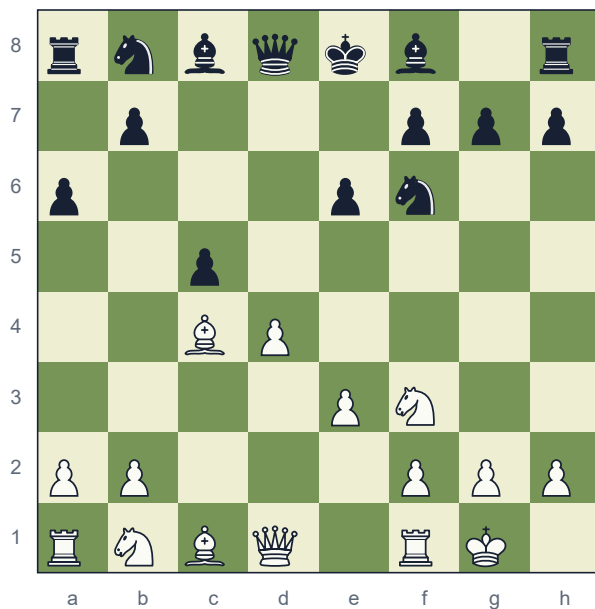
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Classical development

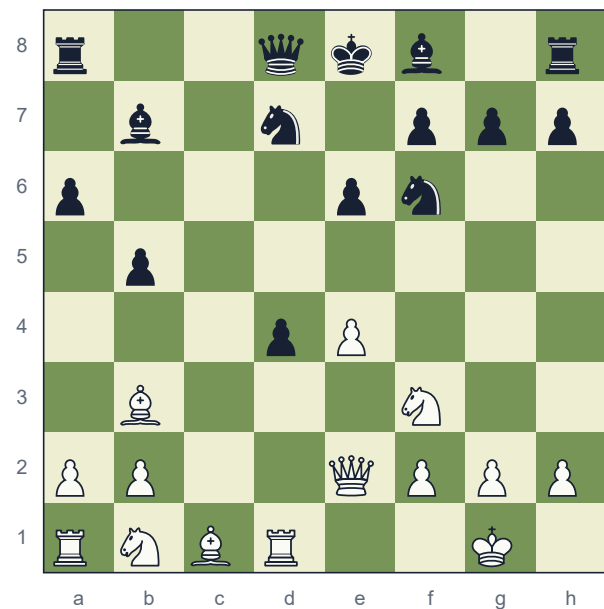
STUDY LINE 04-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O a6 7. Qe2 b5 8. Bb3 Bb7 9. Rd1 Nbd7 10. e4 cxd4

Selected anchor ends with 9. Rd1. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 opens the bishop and Bxc4 recovers the pawn with development. Qe2 and Rd1 build pressure on the central file.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the b1 knight to c3 or d2 according to tactics. Watch ...cxd4 and decide which piece or pawn should recapture.

WATCH FOR

Do not push d5 just because the rook is on d1; make sure the resulting exchanges do not lose the center.

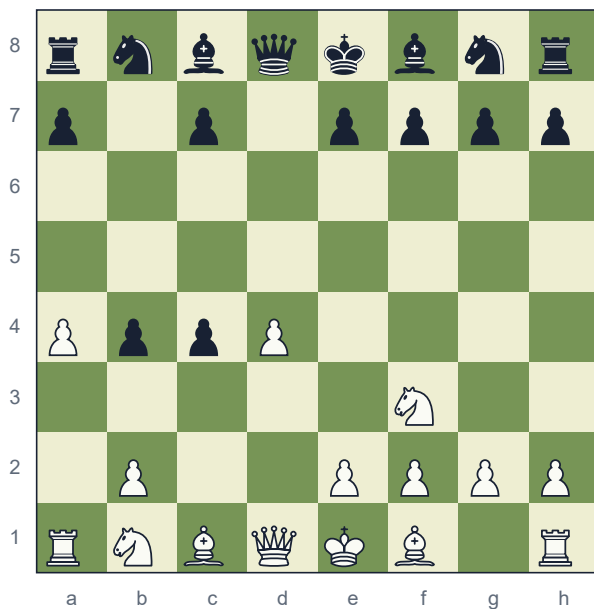
REMEMBER Recover with the bishop and bring a rook to the center.

02 Black tries to hold with ...b5

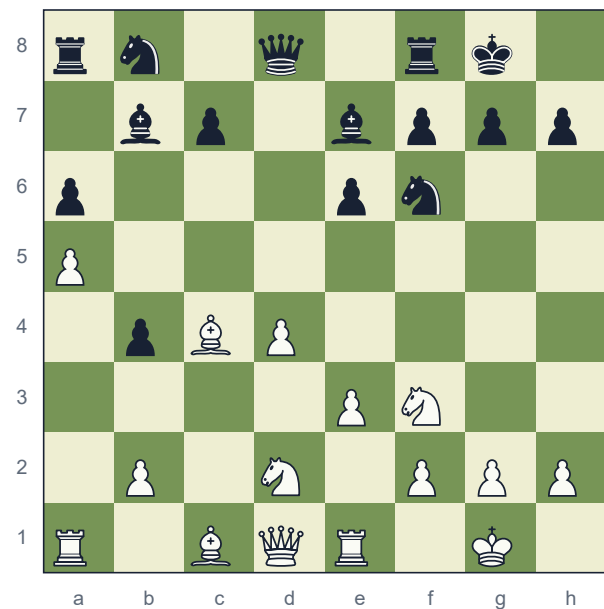
STUDY LINE 04-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 b5 4. a4 b4 5. e3 Nf6 6. Bxc4 e6 7. a5 a6 8. O-O Bb7 9. Nbd2 Be7 10. Re1 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 attacks the base of Black's chain. After ...b4, e3 opens lines and prepares to recover c4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bxc4 when safe, castle, and exploit the queenside weaknesses. Material is less important than getting your pieces out while Black spends pawn moves.

WATCH FOR

After ...b4, a knight developed automatically to c3 can be attacked with tempo.

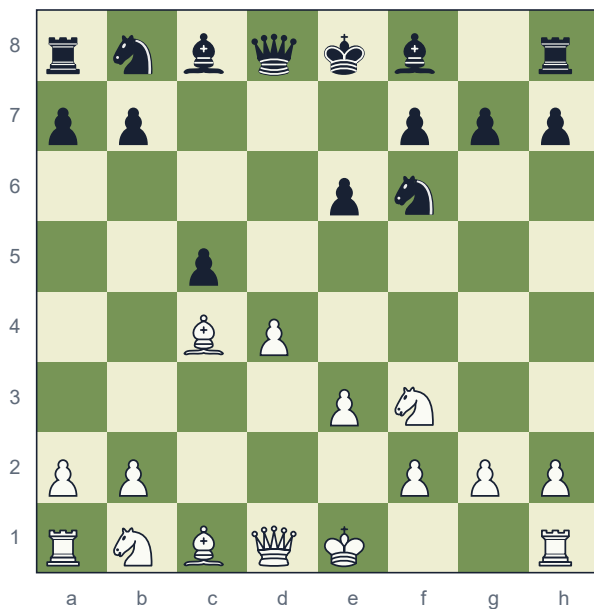
REMEMBER Undermine the support of the captured pawn.

03 An immediate ...c5

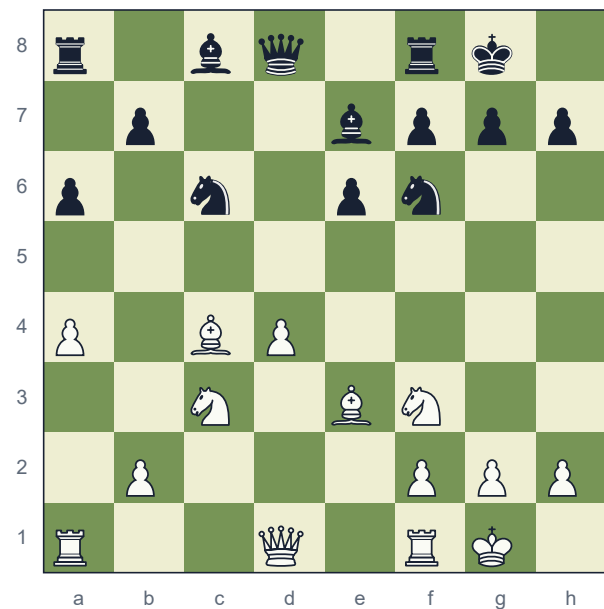
STUDY LINE 04-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Bxc4 e6 6. O-O a6 7. a4 cxd4 8. exd4 Nc6 9. Nc3 Be7 10. Be3 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 6. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The same development scheme works. The key is that your e-pawn is still available to support or recapture in the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Nc3 and Qe2 are useful, with the d-file becoming important after central exchanges.

WATCH FOR

An early dxc5 can leave e4 available to Black and should not be played by habit.

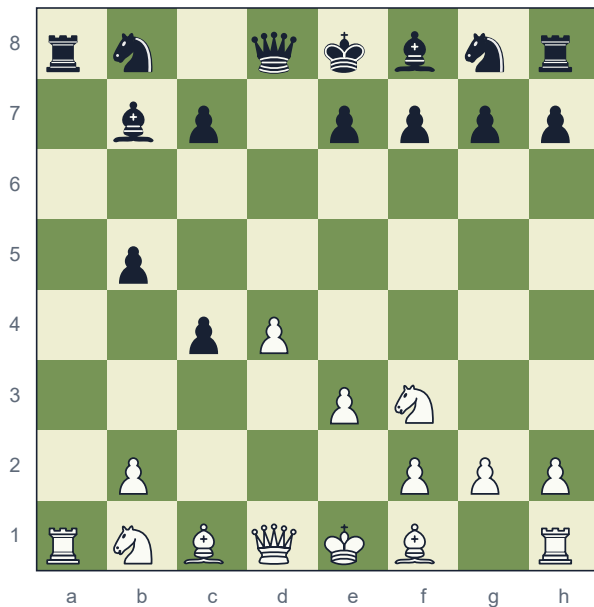
REMEMBER Keep development ahead of pawn collecting.

04 Black prepares ...b5 with ...a6

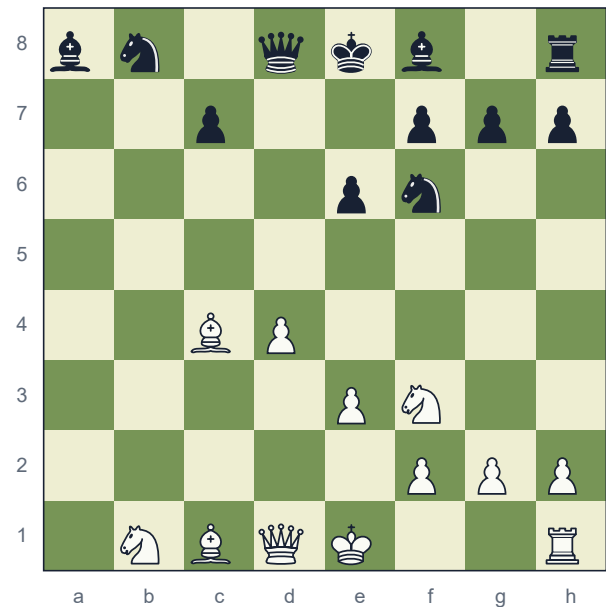
STUDY LINE 04-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8 8. b3 e6 9. bxc4 bxc4 10. Bxc4 Nf6

Selected anchor ends with 7... Bxa8. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 immediately asks whether Black can hold the extra pawn without concessions. Trading the a-rooks can leave b5 and c4 as targets.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Continue developing and recover c4 at the right moment. The open files favor pieces already in play.

WATCH FOR

Check rook exchanges all the way through: a missing rook is not a free bishop on a8.

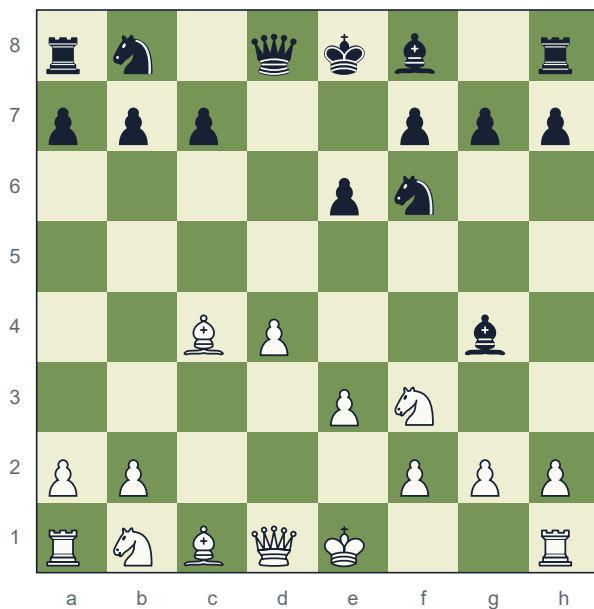
REMEMBER Challenge ...b5 before it becomes comfortable.

05 A pin with ...Bg4

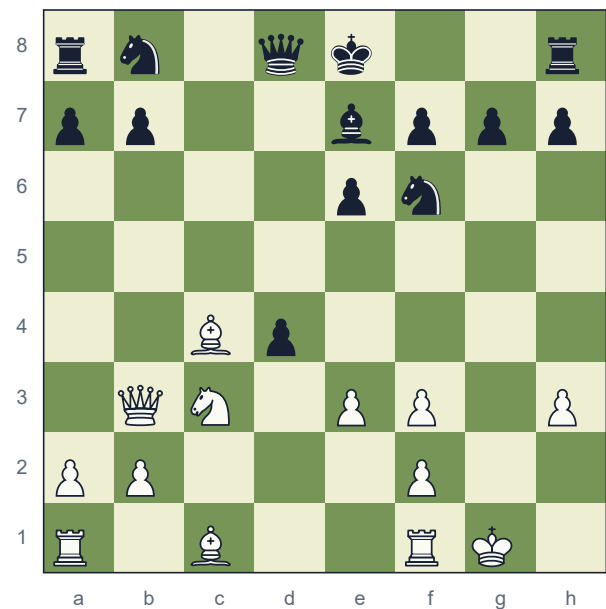
STUDY LINE 04-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. e3 Nf6 5. Bxc4 e6 6. O-O Be7 7. Nc3 c5 8. h3 Bh5 9. Qb3 Bxf3 10. gxf3 cxd4

Selected anchor ends with 6. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 and Bxc4 are enough to maintain a sound position. You can tolerate the pin while the king reaches safety.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

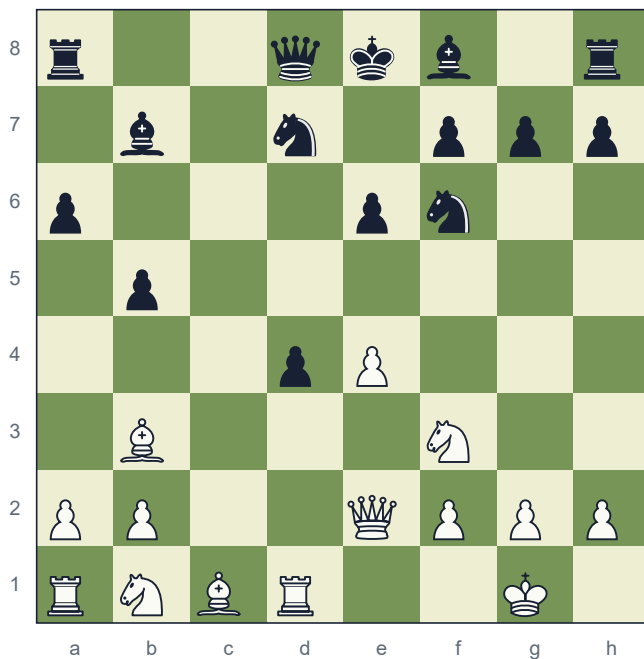
Use Nc3 and h3 only when it helps. If Black exchanges on f3, choose the recapture that suits the center and king safety.

WATCH FOR

h3 is not obligatory if it merely encourages a useful bishop exchange for Black.

REMEMBER Develop through the pin; challenge it on your terms.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

After ...c5 and exchanges on d4, White may have an isolated d-pawn. Before that, the open center and quick development are the important features.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black returns the pawn to develop freely, or tries ...b5 to hold it. The latter often gives you targets for a4 and undermining moves.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the b1 knight to c3 or d2 according to tactics. Watch ...cxd4 and decide which piece or pawn should recapture.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.